

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS



QUADRILATERAL ALLIANCE

MODULE - 53

- 1** The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue or Quad, comprising of Australia, India, Japan and the United States is gaining attention at a time when China's rise and concurrent assertiveness have sparked concern across the region.
- 2** Members of this quadrilateral are a group of democratic countries advocating a free and open Indo-Pacific for shared peace and prosperity.
- 3** The idea of the Quad could be originally attributed to Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe who first mentioned it in his book *Utsukushii Kuni-e* (A beautiful country).



4 It got operationalized in 2007, but failed to gain any traction. The idea was revived in 2017 with US pitching for greater engagement and cooperation among democratic powers.

5 Japan proposed a revival while India and Australia expressed willingness for discussing the same.

6 Since then, three joint secretary-level meetings involving the Quad countries have taken place



NEED FOR QUAD

- 1 China's hegemonic designs are a growing cause of concern for countries like India, Japan, Vietnam, the Philippines, and other Asian states.
- 2 Beijing is using its enhanced military capabilities to pressure neighbouring countries by asserting its territorial claims.
- 3 Its transgressions in Doklam and India's Arunachal Pradesh, constantly pressuring Japan over Senkaku islands (referred by China as Diaoyu islands), threatening Vietnam over drilling oil in the areas of South China Sea, and blatantly ignoring the 2016 verdict favoring the Philippines on the South China Sea exemplify this drive towards a unilateral assertion of interests.



NEED FOR QUAD

4 The economic benefits emanating from China's rise has turned into a security threat. China's aggressive behaviour over the last decade led to the revival of the Quad 2.0 at the ASEAN summit in Manila in 2017.

5 All the four countries in their separate briefings emphasised, among other things, the free and open Indo-Pacific, a rules-based order, freedom of navigation and respect for international law, and maritime security, all code words for managing China.



CONTEMPORARY REALITIES

- 1 Thus, the shift in the epicentre of global politics from the trans-Atlantic to the Indo-Pacific marked by America's relative decline and the rise of China has significant geopolitical implications for the region.
- 2 Although the ongoing uncertainty is bound to have global repercussion, Asian states will be at the forefront of this strategic flux.
- 3 This is intertwined with their security and sovereignty.



CONTEMPORARY REALITIES

4 Asian states benefited from the U.S.-led post-Cold War order and now America's withdrawal from that order as a result of an increasing inward focus is causing anxiety in these states regarding the future of the liberal order and the U.S. capability and willingness to defend it.

5 The US believes the Quad is an extremely important element of its larger Indo-Pacific strategy for a 'free, open and rules-based order in face of an aggressive and expansionist China in the region.

6 A quest for new connectivity corridors across the bay has renewed its geo-economic significance while highlighting its strategic undertones.



STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK OF QUAD

1 Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (QSD), was an informal strategic dialogue platform among the member countries of QUAD.

2

- To further coordination in the QSD, a large-scale joint naval exercise called **Malabar** was also held.

- The QSD faded away when Australia withdrew from it due to the growing tension between the US and China in the Asia-Pacific, and the growing contradictions in Australia's approach to it.

3 Meanwhile, India, Japan, and the US continued to hold joint naval exercises through Malabar.

4 The present composition of the organisation was shaped in 2017.



STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK OF QUAD

■ The strategic convergence of the Quad members is based on the following factors:

- 1 The forum was implicitly concerned mostly about China.
- 2 QUAD members have described the grouping as an alignment of like-minded countries that share common strategic and economic interests.
- 3 The only factor binding them in this enterprise are their disputes with China in their own littoral waters, which collectively span the Indian Ocean Region (IOR), the SCS, the East China Sea (ECS), and the Pacific Ocean Region.



QUAD PLUS

- 1 Additional partners called 'plus' countries could provide critical perspective.
- 2 The attempt to include others is expected to allow Quad to explore for synergies in approaches to China, especially on lines of maritime security.
- 3 The relationships of these countries with China will be affected in diplomatic, security, economic and other domains by what the Quad does
- 4 Coordination among the Quad countries will not essentially be about economics. It should be strictly about minimizing direct security risks.
- 5 There is a synergy in value systems as Quad countries are liberal democracies.



QUAD 2.0

- 1 On November 12, 2017, the four countries formally met in Manila and renamed the Quad framework into Quad 2.0
- 2 Instead of releasing a joint statement, the countries had four different press releases, indicating how their strategic objectives and preferences in the region differ from each other.
- 3 The release of these four separate press releases was indicative of Quad 2.0 being simply a consultative forum among the four countries. A commonality in agenda was missing in action.
- 4 There was also a collective endorsement of upholding rule-based order



QUAD 2.0

- 5 The Quad's growth trajectory from 1.0 to 2.0 corresponds to China's rapid rise as a military and economic power.
- 6 The prime context behind Quad 2.0 is Beijing's Maritime Silk Road (MSR), which is an integral part of China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) under Xi Jinping.
- 7
 - Since 2003-04, China has been focusing more on critical maritime infrastructure, emphasizing key maritime zones, investment in port construction, protection of maritime zones and finding alternative routes in the Indo-Pacific region.
 - Countries like Maldives, Sri Lanka and Djibouti have shown significant interest in China's maritime investment projects.



QUAD 2.0

- 8 These Chinese actions encourage India to participate in a consultative forum like the Quad.
- 9 China has not only maintained a stable economic growth but increased its military expenditure, causing concern in India and around the world.
- 10 It has affected relations between nations in Asia and overall economic and political landscape.



INDIA IN THE QUAD

- 1** India aspires to become the 'net security provider' in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR) and aims for the Indian Navy to operate a 200-ship fleet by 2027.
- 2** Given India's geographical location and other factors, the Indian Navy prioritises the IOR's security cover over those of the South China Sea (SCS), East China Sea (ECS) and the Pacific.
- 3** Strategically, India would focus and modernise its military platforms in the IOR instead of the SCS and beyond.



INDIA IN THE QUAD

4 India's would not want to divide its naval assets between IOR and SCS as it would weaken India's presence in the IOR, and dilute strategic depth.

5 In this regard, China's relationship with the IOR countries, including the South Asian countries, has been given utmost importance.

6 For instance, China's relationships with the Maldives, Nepal, Bhutan and Sri Lanka are challenging not only India's influence and investment interests in its immediate neighbourhood but the other Quad countries interests in the IOR.

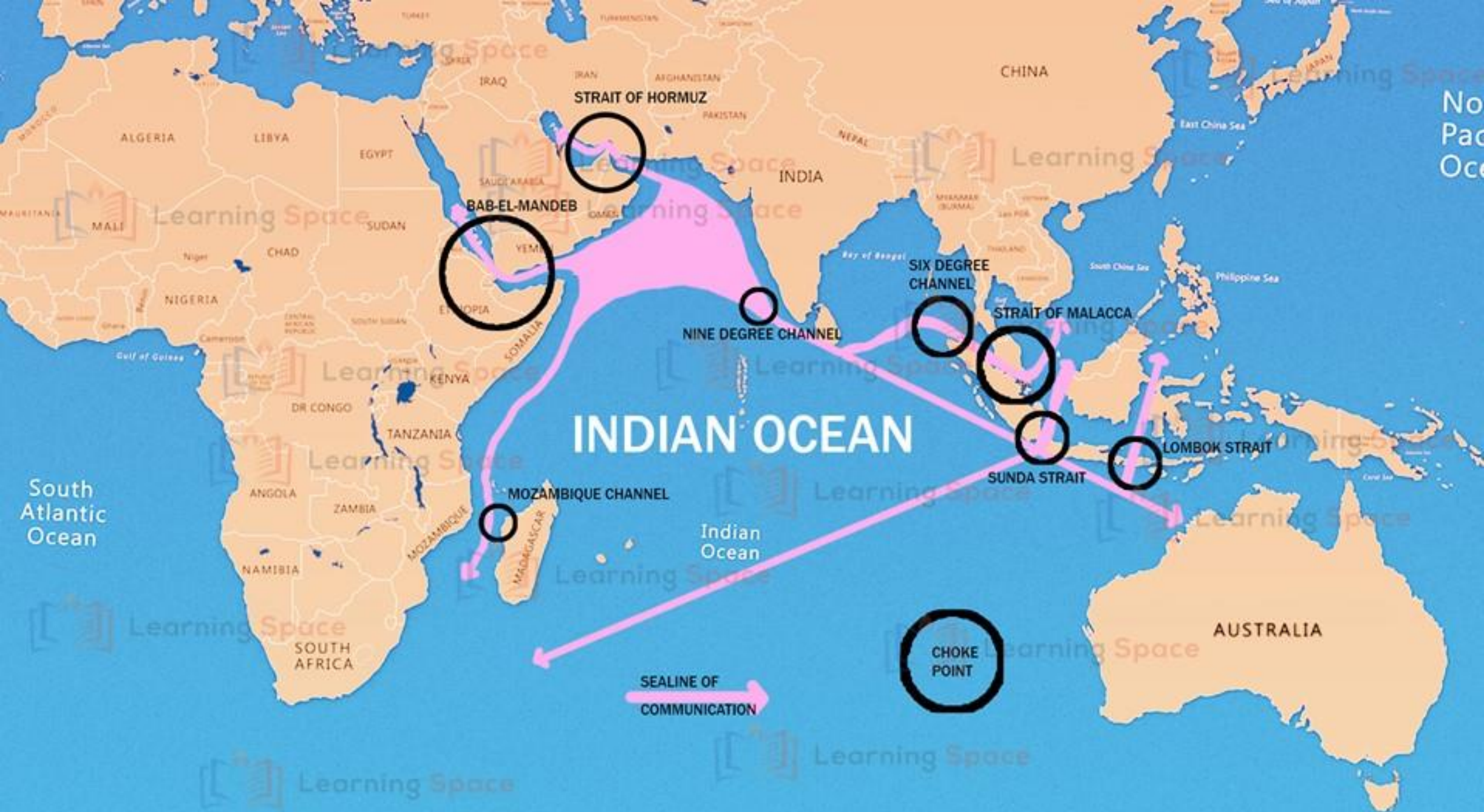


INDIA IN THE QUAD

India's importance to Quad 2.0 has been termed the “strategic fulcrum” of the Indo-Pacific.

- 1** Australia sees India as a “significant strategic partner” in the IOR.
- 2** Japan views India as a key strategic partner in Shinzo Abe's Free and Open Indo-Pacific FOIP strategy.
- 3** The US acknowledges India as a “leading global power in the making” in the region. It recently renamed the US Pacific Command as the US Indo-Pacific Command, factoring India's centrality in its Indian Ocean strategy.
- 4** Indian Prime Minister talked about evolving a ‘common rules-based order’ for Quad based on sovereignty, territorial integrity and dialogue. This order would apply to all states and global commons.
- 5** They believe that a ‘free and open Indo-Pacific’ can bring wealth and prosperity to all regional countries.





MARITIME SECURITY INITIATIVES BY INDIA

New Delhi has tried to revitalise its maritime strategy in recent years.

Following Initiatives are intended to protect India's commercial and maritime interests in the IOR

1. Security and Growth for All in the Region (SAGAR)
2. The Cotton Routes
3. The Spice Routes
4. Project Mausam
5. inter-continental consultative framework like the Asia-Africa Growth Corridor (AAGC).

These initiatives aim at empowering India's coastal provinces through the upgrading of infrastructure and by linking them strategically with the IOR countries

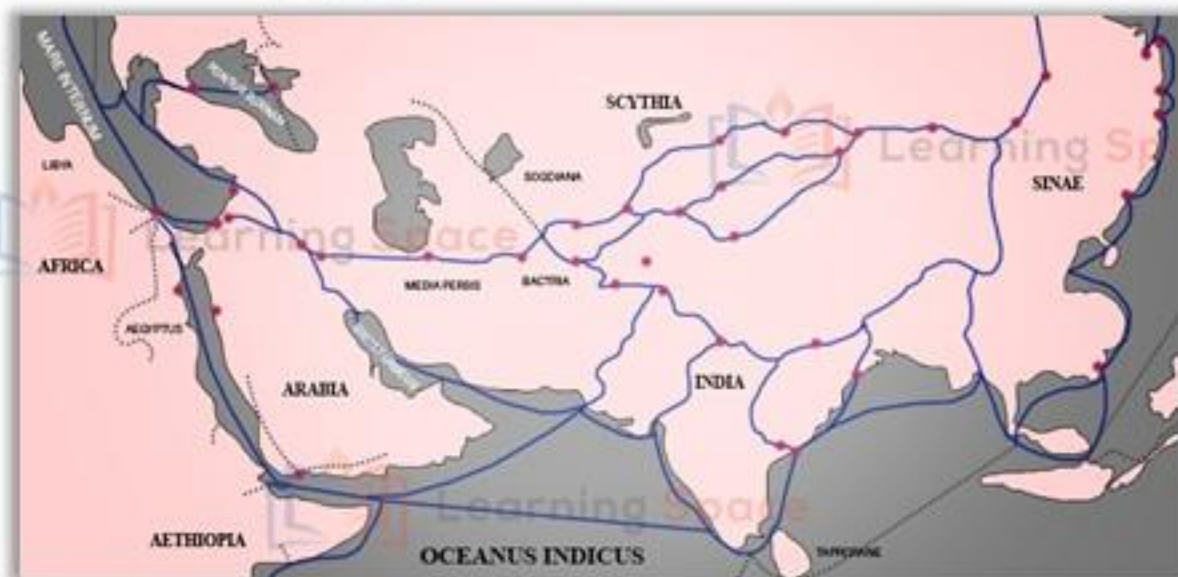


INDIA BALANCING WITH QUAD AND CHINA

1 Post the India-China informal summit in Wuhan in April 2018, India is in a difficult position as QUAD would disturb the balance that India is trying to foster between China and the West. India's denial of Australia's participation in the former's Malabar

2 India's continued association with the RIC and BRICS shows India continues to engage with China and Russia multilaterally, while managing its continued participation in Quad 2.0.

3 India's reluctance to be seen as part of any containment strategy directed at China is based on the apprehension that China could affect regional and international matters for India.



INDIA BALANCING WITH QUAD AND CHINA

- 4 This has led to a persistent decoupling of the Quad from the Indo-Pacific strategy.
- 5 At the Shangri-La Dialogue in 2018, PM Modi clarified India's position on the Indo-Pacific- India does not see the Indo-Pacific region as a strategy or as a club of limited members that seek to dominate.
- 6 India also stood for a positive vision of the Indo-Pacific that focuses on ASEAN centrality and emphasises inclusivity with South East Asia as a core area in the region.



CHALLENGES TO INDIA IN QUAD

India's participation in the grouping is faced by several challenges-

- 1 The Indian Navy will find it difficult to finance deployment and manoeuvres of its fleet in areas where it does not have any primary strategic interests such as the SCS and the Pacific Ocean Region.
- 2 Expenditure incurred in such deployment will non-commercial in nature, and will not converge with India's defence interests due to lack of strategic interests.
- 3 India does not have the logistics related capacity to expand its reach beyond the west of the Malacca Strait to ensure a steady supply of vital spares to the fleet.
- 4 This can be expensive because Indian Navy due to the absence of permanent refuel and repair points along the way and operating fixed wing or rotor aircrafts for this purpose would drastically increase the operating cost.



CHALLENGES BEFORE INDIA IN QUAD

- 1** India cannot solely rely on Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement (LEMOA) with the US and other member states for logistics due to the difference in military hardware.
- 2**
 - The Indian naval fleet is predominantly made up of either Soviet Russian or indigenous platforms whereas the other three navies are entirely made up of western hardware with some indigenous elements.
 - This not only makes logistics a burden but also increases the gap in interoperability.
- 3** A 2017 analysis shows that the Indian Navy alone would require massive recapitalisation worth a minimum of US\$ 40-50 billion annually for the next decade to bridge this gap.
- 4** Beijing's emergence as a stronger "maritime power" has endangered the Quad members' strategic interests.



CHALLENGES BEFORE INDIA IN QUAD

- 5 Some divergences appear in the Quad grouping. India is yet to agree to Australia's request to join the Malabar exercise.
- 6 Malabar exercise began as a bilateral naval exercise between India and the US in 1992 and has grown in scope and complexity in the recent years.
- 7 In 2015 it was expanded into a trilateral format with the inclusion of Japan.
- 8 Each country involved has conflicting internal interests, not to mention conflicting interests with one another.



QUAD AND ASEAN

- 1 It is challenging to make ASEAN join the Quad.
- 2 PM Modi highlighted the importance of the ASEAN in regional integration because of its strategic location in the Indian and Pacific Ocean.
- 3 The meeting of the so-called Quad countries on the side-lines of 13th East Asian summit in Singapore, the participants stressed ASEAN's centrality and committed themselves to partnering with multiple countries and forums to promote rule-based, open, free and inclusive Indo-Pacific



EVALUATION OF QUAD

- 1 The Quad is a reflection of this evolving post-Cold War contest between the US and China.
- 2 Japan, as a strategic ally of the US, has contributed a great deal to enhance the formulation of the Quad.
- 3 Australia and India have further enhanced it by participating in this proposition.
 - The Quad needs to focus on two major challenges-
 1. Offer a credible alternative to countries burdened with debt resulting from their participation in China's Belt and Road Initiative.
 2. Deter Chinese militarisation of the South China Sea.



WAY FORWARD

- 1** The Quad could collaborate on actionable issue areas like piracy. All four countries have an impressive naval capability.
- 2** The U.S. Indo-Pacific Command could use drones for monitoring major trade routes and facilitate real-time information exchange with ASEAN countries like Indonesia, Philippines, Malaysia, and Singapore.
- 3** It should focus on building a robust regional consultation mechanism and coordinate with ASEAN nations on issues of regional importance.



WAY FORWARD

4 Initiatives like the Indo-Pacific business forum could be expanded to encourage private investment in crucial sectors like energy, the digital economy, the blue economy, and infrastructure.

5 To maintain robust capabilities in the IOR, India can build-up its sea denial and control capabilities by enhancing naval capabilities and re-calibrating bilateral ties with littoral countries in East of IOR such as Indonesia and key ASEAN members like Vietnam.

6 This would enhance bilateral relations and augment intelligence sharing.

India should move constructively to make the Quad a support system of its Indo-Pacific strategy.



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